

Response Times

The response time is the time it takes for a pixel to change its state from on to off or from off to on. These times for LCD monitors have traditionally been slower than those of CRTs. The effect of this can be seen in the form of trails following bright, fast moving objects, and also leads to blurry images. This spoils the movie-watching or gaming experience.

Newer LCDs have a lower response time, so their pixels switch much faster—allowing you to view movies and play games without the problems that were previously associated with LCDs.

At 12 ms, the BenQ FP51G had the fastest response time amongst the 15-inch LCDs. The ViewSonic VX922, which is touted as the world's "fastest" LCD monitor, boasted of an incredibly low 6 ms response time which, using proprietary techniques, they claim to boost to 2 ms, making it good enough for any purpose, gaming included. Similarly, the Asus PM17TU in the 17-inch category also claims to achieve a low response time of 3 ms using a proprietary technique. 8 ms was the lowest response time in the remainder of the 17- and 19-inch monitors. A response time of 8 ms is fine for watching movies, but may not be good enough for fast-paced games.

Dimensions

When you talk about an LCD monitor, you instantly think of a compact device with sleek dimensions—so much more attractive than a bulky CRT monitor!

In the 15-inch category, the BenQ FP51G had the smallest dimensions: 330 x 337 x 134.6 mm. In the 17-inch category, the LG FLA-TRON L1730S had the smallest dimensions. The NU L921G had the lowest dimensions and footprint in the 19-inch category, making it the sleekest 19-inch panel.

Weight

It's not often that you change the physical placement of your monitor. The weight is therefore not that important as far as a monitor is concerned. But it is always nice to have a lighter monitor, isn't it? Interestingly though, heavy monitors tend to be steadier on their feet—more stable on a table.

Of the 15-inch monitors, the Acer AL1515sm was the lightest at 3 kg, whereas the Samsung Sync-

Master 540N was the heaviest at 4.5 kg. The CMV CT-712A was the lightest at 3.4kg, while the BenQ FP72V was the heaviest at 7.5 kg in the 17-inch category. Amongst the 19-inch LCDs, the CMV CT-937A weighed in at just 4.7 kg which is quite light for a 19-inch monitor, while the NEC Multi-

Sync LCD1980FXi was the heaviest of the lot.

Flexibility

Height adjustment allows you to set the monitor at a level that is most comfortable for viewing. This feature is very useful as far as ergonomics and comfort is concerned. If the monitor does not allow for this, you might need to adjust the height of your chair, which is not always possible.

Height adjustment was entirely absent in the 15-inch category. Amongst the 17-inchers, the BenQ FP72V and the NEC MultiSync monitors supported height adjustment. In the 19-inch category, the Asus PW191 and NEC MultiSync had this feature.

A few LCDs also have the horizontal and vertical swivel feature, which is an added bonus. This lets you adjust the monitor's angle to suit your comfort levels.

All the monitors supported vertical tilt, a feature missing in many monitors in our last LCD test. There were quite a few monitors that also featured horizontal swivel adjustment; prominent amongst them were the Asus PW191, the LG 1950SQ and the NEC MultiSync LCD1970NXp in the 19-inch category. Amongst the 17-inchers, the NEC MultiSync LCD1770NX and the NEC MultiSync LCD1770NXm featured swivel.

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BenQ FP51G

Other Features

Most graphics cards today, even entry-level ones, feature a DVI interface. DVI provides a pure digital video signal, and if your monitor supports the input, then the necessity of conversion between analog and digital signals is eliminated. The result is a lossless transfer of the video signal, and the overall image quality being better than with the D-sub interface.

This interface was not found in any of the 15-inch monitors, but was featured on a few 17-inchers and on most of the 19-inch models.

The 17-inch BenQ FP72V also featured two side-panel speakers and a USB Web cam on top, making it a good integrated solution. The 19-inch Asus PW191 was the only LCD monitor with feather-touch controls, but as we found out, it was difficult to use—the controls were unresponsive most of the time. Also, it was difficult to view the controls in a moderately lit room with the monitor turned off.

The NEC AccuSync LCD 1770NXM was the only monitor that sported a USB hub, providing a convenient way to connect multiple input devices to your PC.

Power Consumption

One of the better known pluses of LCDs is their low power consumption. However, it is also true that their power requirements are often not substantially lower than those of CRTs. 15-inch LCDs need anything between 25 W and 36 W. 17-inchers need between 40 W and 60 W of power, and the power requirements of 19-inch LCDs are similar to 17-inch units. You should check the

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